



Spotlight On: The Leaders Behind Three Inspiring Local CSPs

On 5 January 2026, **Project Inspirar**, **Project Kiddleidoscope**, and **starringSMU**, supported by Central Singapore CDC's Giraffe Do-Good Grant, came together for a grand celebration filled with heartfelt speeches, performances, and cherished moments with their beneficiaries. Meet the leaders behind these three projects as they share their stories, lessons, and what the finale meant to them.

Q

Take us back to the very first day you met your beneficiaries. What was that moment like, and did anything catch you off guard?



A

I'll be honest, I was scared — standing there, completely unsure of what was 'appropriate' or how to act. I was so worried about overstepping that I was stuck in my own head. But that fear vanished once I stopped overthinking. They weren't looking for a 'perfect' volunteer; they just wanted someone to be there with them. It was a wake-up call to stop worrying about the 'rules' and focus on the human connection.

Glenn Yeo Jin Rong
President, starringSMU



Q



Was there a moment during the project where things didn't go as planned — and how did that change the way you approached everything after?



A

We had planned a whole AI art activity, but right before the session, the AV system stopped working. We improvised — each volunteer went around showing elderly participants AI art on our phones in small groups instead. We thought it would be less engaging, but it turned out even better. That experience taught me that intimate, personal interactions often beat polished large-scale presentations. Sometimes the backup plan is the better plan.

Joshua Cher Zhi Rui
President, Project Inspirar

Q

What did your beneficiaries teach you that no classroom ever could?

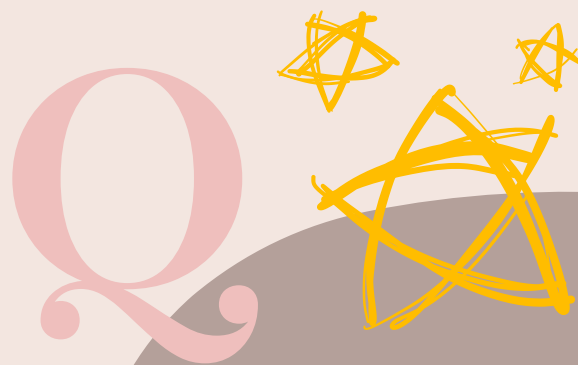


A

My beneficiaries taught me how to have fun with boundaries. Children are inherently energetic, but as a project leader, the goal wasn't just fun — it was holistic growth. When children became disrespectful, I had to put my foot down and remind them of the rules. This taught me that boundaries and fun aren't mutually exclusive.

Elizabeth Tan Ting Shan
Vice President, Project Kiddleidoscope





On the finale day, when all three projects came together — what was that experience like for you and your team?



Seeing nearly 200 beneficiaries, staff, and partners in one space was remarkable — but what really got me was watching the elderly light up during the old school games. They were often better than us, laughing, cheering, hugging and thanking us repeatedly. Some rarely leave their facilities, yet here they were, reconnecting with childhood memories. That's when it hit me: we hadn't just run a successful event — we had created real moments of joy.

Joshua Cher Zhi Rui
President, Project Inspirar



Q



If you could go back and say one thing to yourself on the first day of this project, what would it be?



A

I would tell myself: 'You're exactly where you're meant to be.' There were so many uncertainties at the start, but every obstacle and small success shaped my growth as a leader. This journey taught me that deep fulfilment comes from serving others — and that even imperfections are what make it truly impactful.

Shermaine Sa Jia En
Vice President, starringSMU





About the projects

Project Inspirar - Established in 2008, Project Inspirar bridges generational divides through meaningful connections between SMU students and Singapore's elderly community. This student-led initiative recognises that active engagement and genuine friendship can significantly enhance the quality of life for older adults while promoting healthy aging in Singapore's rapidly graying society. Find out more [here](#).

Project Kiddleidoscope - Initiated in 2013, Project Kiddleidoscope empowers children from less privileged backgrounds to pursue their dreams through confidence-building activities and creative expression opportunities. Find out more [here](#).

starringSMU - Started in 2007, starringSMU holds the distinction of being SMU's longest-running student-led community service project, demonstrating nearly two decades of sustained commitment to disability advocacy and support. The initiative focuses on empowering persons with disabilities and special needs by equipping them with fundamental life skills essential for successful integration into broader society, while simultaneously raising public awareness about disability issues and capabilities. Find out more [here](#).

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